Cleaning and drilling the seat with hand tools

1 Before the final shaping we need to drill the holes in the underside of the seat to take the legs later on. Here you can clearly see how the sight lines work. Keep the sight line in line with the drill and drill on the bradawl point you made when marking out the blank. The sight line will give you the correct splay

2 This picture shows the drilling in process. Using a hinge board to give you the correct drilling angle which, in this case, is 10° for the front legs and 15° for the back legs

3 Now the seat has been roughed out, move on to the fine shaping. To start with use a couple of spokeshaves, one flat and one with a slight convex curved profile. Together these will do most of the final shaping, however, help from other tools like pull shaves and travishers will also be useful

4 Clean up to the shaped edge of the seat with a cabinet scraper prior to sanding. Try to work with the grain in order to prevent tearing

5 When you are happy with the shaping of the seat and it feels comfortable to sit in, flatten off the top to crisp up the second template line. So that you don't have a clamp or bench dog in the way here, use a sacrificial bench board to which stop blocks can be screwed to keep the work piece from slipping

6 You will now begin to see the finished top shape. Continue to shape the underside by curling up the edges with a spokeshave and planing the bottom before sanding the seat all over

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Turning the legs and stretchers

1 Now on to the turning: we're going to start with the legs, which should have all been cut to the same length of 460mm. Mount the leg onto the lathe and rough the blank down to round. I'm using a favourite shape of mine, that works well on the larger chair

2 I enjoy the discipline of copy turning but also the freedom of creating the shape of the first leg. Be sure to take your time turning the legs and tweak the design until you are happy. I use source material from books, the Internet and my memory. Position the drill on the leg, for the stretcher to fit into, 200mm down from the top of the leg, and avoid any intricate design in this section

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